

Opinion

Should you tip on a carry-out pizza? And other modern tipping quandaries

BY DAVID HUDNALL
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A few weeks ago at Kauffman Stadium, a friend and I went to grab beers for our group. He bought the first round; I hung out in line and waited to help carry them back.

Four Boulevard Brewing Company drafts came out to something like \$64, though it might have been a little more than that.

He tapped his card, and then came the tip prompt.

I watched him eye the screen, which offered default options of 15%, 20% and 25%. He tapped 20%, adding about \$12 to the total. That's roughly \$3 per beer to the bartender for pulling a handle, work that took maybe 45 seconds.

I watched my friend tip and knew I would have done the same thing a few weeks earlier. But I'd recently made a resolution to pay closer attention to how, and why, I tip. That shift started with a conversation with a University of Kansas marketing professor named Rob Waiser.

Waiser and several colleagues recently published a Harvard Business Review article titled "When Tipping Becomes a Customer Experience Problem." It lays out how tipping in recent years has spread into

unlikely corners of the economy, and examines how it can either enhance or damage the customer experience depending on how it's implemented.

The piece is aimed at businesses, urging them to think more carefully about how aggressive tipping prompts can backfire. But it's rooted in an idea most people intuitively understand: Tipping in this country has gone off the rails.

The point of a tip, Waiser told me, is for customers to decide how much they want to pay for service — to show their appreciation.

"But that's not really how people are deciding their tips anymore. You're tipping because you think the worker is underpaid, or because you're standing there at a coffee shop, and they flip the screen around and the barista is watching you and the people behind you can see what you do."

"You no longer feel like you can give a tip based on the service you received," he said. "You're tipping based on things like social pressure or empathy or embarrassment, which are things that really shouldn't have anything to do with tipping."

PAY FOR FOOD, ALSO SERVICE IN RESTAURANTS

Waiser and his co-au-

thors boil tipping down to three principles: distinctiveness, visibility and proportionality. I don't own a business, but as a tipper I've found the framework to be useful in my everyday life.

Distinctiveness is the idea that tipping only makes sense when there's a clear service component separate from what you're already paying for. Example: At a restaurant, you pay for the food, but you also pay for the service that exists alongside it.

"And that service could be good or bad, so you tip accordingly," Waiser said. "But your tip is distinct from the meal you're paying for."

Contrast that with the video game industry, where CEOs have floated the idea of letting players tip developers after finishing a game they liked.

"There's nothing distinct happening there besides purchasing the game," Waiser said. "You buy the game. You're paying for the game. There's no other service being provided that you should tip for."

Then there's visibility. Tipping assumes the customer can actually evaluate the service. In a bar or restaurant, you can see whether someone is working hard or loafing, whether they're friendly or rude. But at an auto shop — another

area where tipping has made inroads — you don't know if the mechanic has properly fixed your car when you pick it up. You only know later if it breaks down.

"So at the time that I would be paying for that service, there's nothing visible to me that I can base a tip on," Waiser said. "There's nothing that would allow me to make a decision on how much to tip that person, because the service itself is not visible."

BASELINE OF 20%?

And then there's proportionality, which is the one that gets bent most often.

In theory, tips are supposed to scale with service: better experience, higher tip; worse experience, lower one. In practice, that's not how most people behave. The percentage is usually fixed before the service even begins — 20% not as a reward, but as a baseline.

"I think if you ask most people how much they tip, it doesn't really depend very much on how good the service was — everybody sort of has their amount that they tip based on how they feel about themselves as a tipper, or based on how much compassion they have for the workers, and so on," Waiser said.

If everyone is expected to tip roughly the same

amount regardless of what happens, the connection between performance and pay weakens. The tip is not proportional to the quality of service. "The way one of my coauthors put it is 'monetizing empathy,'" Waiser said. "It's this idea of businesses depending on customers having empathy for the workers. As a customer, you end up tipping because you have this general sense that the workers aren't getting paid enough otherwise."

'THEY JUST HAND YOU THE SCREEN, AND THE SCREEN ASKS'

The main reason tipping can feel so overwhelming lately isn't especially mysterious. It's the same thing reshaping much of daily life: technology.

Not long ago, asking for a tip in an unusual setting required a person to actually ask. That was awkward enough that most didn't. Now it's built into the payment.

"They just hand you the screen, and the screen asks," Waiser said. "It's a lot easier for places that haven't been traditionally tipped businesses to start asking for tips."

That shift has expanded tipping into — no joke — self-checkouts, airlines and doctor's offices. It's easy enough to smash "No tip"

in those kinds of ludicrous settings. But others are murkier.

One of my hidden agendas in talking to Waiser was to get him to weigh in a dilemma I regularly face. If you call in a pizza for pickup (or some other to-go order), you're more than likely going to end up staring at a screen asking you to tip, usually with those preselected 15%, 20% and 25% options. But why tip as if it's delivery or table service when you're the one who's done all the work?

My policy is to override the defaults and tip a buck or two, though sometimes I hit the 20% out of habit, forgetting briefly where I am and how little service I've been provided. And more and more, I'm not sure I should pay that buck or two at all.

"I've stopped tipping in situations like that," Waiser said. "That's one of those situations where I've decided that I'm not going to reflexively tip because I feel guilty because you've asked me for one."

On the other hand, Waiser added, "I'm probably tipping the restaurant workers who do serve me — waiters and bartenders — more as a result of doing this research. Because the research also made me aware of how low the tipped minimum wage is here in Kansas."

He's right about that; we're going to talk about it later this week. But first, I'll have another column about what happened when a local business tried to eliminate tipping.

FROM PAGE 11A

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carefully into the surface so that it dried quickly and left no trace of having been applied at all. The goal: invisibility and restoration.

I said I could do that. She seemed satisfied. I had the job. I would report at 9 p.m. the next evening and work 9 p.m. to 6 a.m. — the graveyard shift. I joined a small team that moved through the temporary galleries after closing, removing smudges from the walls, touching up scuff marks, restoring the exhibit space before the next day's crowds arrived. The supervisor's instructions were clear: Take your time, don't rush, keep your brush dry, err on the side of too little rather than too much paint. And then, with particular emphasis: Do not — under any circumstances — spill paint on the red carpet. The walls could be touched up. The carpet could not.

The complete transformation of the museum for the exhibit was a sight to behold. The moment you stepped through the front doors, you were somewhere else entirely. Temporary exhibit walls carved the grand interior into a new series of smaller galleries connected like a maze. The galleries were painted in a warm salmon color with deep red carpet underfoot, together creating something wholly transportive, a world apart from the majestic marble and neutral tones of the familiar Nelson-Atkins.

Completing the journey were the sounds of Chinese bronze bells — deep, resonant, otherworldly tones playing on a continuous loop, 24/7, throughout the entire exhibit. During the day, with galleries full of visitors, the bells accompanied the

murmur of voices and the shuffle of feet to create a unique and captivating experience.

But in the quiet hours of the night shift, the sounds were something else altogether. Alone in the galleries in the wee hours of the morning, brushing out fingerprints while ancient bronzes caught the soft exhibition lighting and the bells rang on, the effect was not transcendence so much as a quiet faraway awareness. The artifacts felt more present, more enduring. A bronze vessel cast thousands of years before did not require my admiration to be remarkable. It simply was what it was, patient and indifferent, outlasting dynasties and oceans and whatever small concerns occupied an economics student working the night shift.

GALLOPING HORSE A CROWN JEWEL

The best part — the part that made the graveyard shift worth more than the pay — was that I got to really see, really experience the exhibit. The crown jewel was the Galloping Horse, a Han Dynasty bronze of breathtaking lightness and motion, a horse in full stride with one hoof balanced impossibly on the back of a swallow in flight. During public hours, it drew such crowds that getting close proved no small feat, and if you managed it, you found yourself too near to take it in properly. You came away with a glimpse, a sliver of an impression.

But in the peaceful, solitary hours we worked, the Galloping Horse was ours. No crowds, no jockeying for position. As we moved between our assigned tasks restoring the exhibit to its pristine state, we could take a moment.

Stand back and let your eyes find the thing whole — the impossible balance of it, the sculptor's artistic genius in rendering speed and weightlessness in bronze. You could move around it, approach slowly, step back again. You could simply look, for as long as you wanted, in silence broken only by the bells. That was the unexpected gift of those hours at the museum.

Looking back on those seven weeks in the spring of 1975, I was probably too young to fully grasp the historical significance of what I was witnessing, but I sensed something extraordinary taking shape. The exhibition marked a historic diplomatic moment, but equally important, it stood as living proof of how art brings people and nations together. Ancient artifacts had crossed the Pacific Ocean bearing 4,000 years of civilization, arriving in the American heartland at a turning point in history. But at the end of my shift, I was still 20-something with modest pay, and by 6 a.m., I was exhausted and mostly thinking about breakfast and sleep.

What I could not have known was how enduring those graveyard hours would prove to be. After more than 50 years, when I close my eyes and think back on those nights at the museum, I can still hear the bronze bells echoing through the galleries and see the lithe, powerful figure of the Flying Horse of Gansu, and I am forever grateful for the memories the Nelson-Atkins Museum of Art gave me that spring of 1975.

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fact that the other attorney's complaints about Ms. Lockhart were wholly inconsistent with Mr. Campbell's own experiences with Ms. Lockhart, Mr. Campbell's isolated remark can only be understood as a misguided overreaction to the complaining attorney, and without expressed discriminatory intent toward Ms. Lockhart," Morrow wrote in court documents. "Mr. Campbell's isolated, rhetorical remark was a lapse of judgment, and Mr. Campbell has admitted the ethical violation."

ADMITTED TO USING RACIAL SLUR

Lockhart first filed a complaint against Campbell almost two years ago after she learned from Platte County Prosecutor Eric Zahnd and first assistant prosecuting attorney Mark Gibson what Campbell had said about her.

In March 2024, Campbell was speaking with another attorney about his

ability to get along with various Platte County assistant prosecutors.

"When the other attorney complained about his recent difficulty obtaining favorable plea offers from Ms. Lockhart, (Campbell) referred to Ms. Lockhart by using a racial slur, asking: 'Is it because she is a (racial epithet)?' court documents state.

In a recent column, I detailed why Campbell should have been suspended. In disciplinary proceedings, he admitted he called Lockhart a racial slur.

"Anything less than a suspension for Campbell would be a slap in the face of every attorney licensed by the Missouri Bar to practice law in the state, no matter the color of their skin," I wrote.

Zahnd, the Platte County prosecutor, said in a statement that he was proud of his office for its unwavering support of Lockhart after she filed her complaint, which I am

sure as the only Black prosecutor in Platte County wasn't an easy thing to do. No one should ever have to think twice about taking a stand against racism, though.

"I am consistently proud of everyone's professionalism and how we all (not just Mark and me) supported Lynnette during this difficult situation," Zahnd wrote in a staff email he shared with me. "Let's continue to uphold justice without fear or favor and without regard to a victim's, witness's, defendant's, or attorney's race, religion, national origin, sex, sexual orientation, or any other attribute."

In her statement, Lockhart said she chose to address the matter through the appropriate channels "because that is what professionalism requires," she wrote. "I respect the Missouri Supreme Court's decision and the process."

I respect the process, too. But it's fair to question the state Supreme Court's final decision to stay Campbell's suspension.

FROM PAGE 11A

DUNMORE

coming habitual offenders.

Missourians understand personal responsibility. We also understand accountability. When someone has lost their license for repeated dangerous speeding, it is entirely reasonable to attach conditions to their restored privilege of driving. We already do exactly this for drunk drivers: Ignition interlock devices are required for many people convicted of driving under the influence across Missouri. Nobody calls that government overreach.

H.B. 3317 would apply the same principle to extreme speeders. It would not imprison anyone. It would not permanently revoke anyone's license. It says: You can drive again — just within the law.

State Rep. Sherri Gallick, the Republican lawmaker carrying this bill, put it plainly: "Missouri families deserve roads where dangerous drivers are held accountable, not just fined and sent back out to do it again. H.B. 3317 gives habitual speeders a path back to driving, while making sure they

can't put the rest of us at risk. This is about personal responsibility and public safety, and that's about as Missouri as it gets."

Missouri's legislature has the chance to make our roads meaningfully safer. I am asking members to consider what this bill means to the families who have already lost someone — and what it could mean to the families who haven't yet.

My mother deserved to come home that night. So does everyone else's.

Asia Dunmore is a Kansas City resident and member of Families for Safe Streets, a project from the 501(c)(3) nonprofit Transportation Alternatives.

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